

Alert: Suspicious service launched

Endpoint: ec2amaz-9oh9aqq

User: NT SERVICE\himds

OS: WindowsServer2022

Verdict: True positive

Alert story Maximize

Process tree	Alert timeline
4:30:55 PM 7/8/2026 7:38:22 AM	[1348] gc_extension_service.exe -k netsvcs
7:38:23 AM	[5524] MpDefenderCoreService.exe
7/15/2026 5:25:23 PM	[6588] MsMpEng.exe
7/14/2026 4:45:11 AM	MsMpEng.exe read lsass.exe process memory
4:45:11 AM	[1144] nssm.exe
4:45:11 AM	[6972] wusvc.exe -server http://172.31.2.203:8888 -group red Malware
4:45:11 AM	[6972] wusvc.exe loaded image wusvc.exe Malware
	An active '' malware Low Detected Hidden
4:45:15 AM	wusvc.exe interacted with file wusvc.exe Malware
	An active '' malware Low Detected Hidden
4:45:11 PM	[5480] nssm.exe
	Suspicious service launched Medium Detected New

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An active "malware"

■ ■ ■ Low | ● Detected | ● Hidden

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Details Recommendations

Alert state

Classification

Not Set

Assigned to

Suppression rule

Alert tuning rule

[Hide alert An active 'SandCat' malware process was detected while executing](#)

Alert details

Alert ID

da969d44d3-b987-48f1-a41e-be8f8744fea3_1

Category

Malware

Detection source

Antivirus

Detected

Service source

Microsoft Defender for Endpoint

Detection status

● Detected

Detection technology

Client

The alert tuning rule to hide a specific alert usually means an Exclusion (allowlist override).

Why was the alert triggered?

System's behavioural analysis or threat intelligence matched a running process against SandCat—which is the default agent name for Caldera, an open-source adversary emulation platform created by MITRE.

This behaviour aligns with MITRE ATT&CK technique T1003.001 (LSASS Credential Dumping), which is why Defender generating a Credential Access alert.

Investigation Findings

Time	Process	Assessment
4:23	wininit.exe	✓ Normal boot process
4:23	services.exe	✓ Normal, later abused to start a suspicious service
4:23	svchost (DcomLaunch)	✓ Normal
4:23	svchost (Schedule)	✓ Normal; investigate scheduled tasks if needed
4:23	svchost (Winmgmt)	✓ Normal; commonly abused for WMI execution
4:23	CryptSvc	✓ Normal
4:23	WpnService	✓ Normal
4:24	amazon-ssm-agent.exe	✓ Legitimate AWS agent; verify remote command history
4:24	MsSense.exe	✓ Microsoft Defender sensor
4:30	himds.exe	✓ Azure Arc agent
4:45	CalderaAgent → nssm.exe	🚩 Suspicious – primary cause of the alert
5:06	BITS	✓ Legitimate; review for malicious downloads if applicable
5:06	WmiApSrv	✓ Normal
5:07–6:07	TrustedInstaller.exe	✓ Windows Update/servicing
5:55	sppsvc.exe	✓ Windows licensing

Conclusion:

- The process tree is mostly composed of legitimate Windows, AWS, Azure, and Microsoft Defender processes.
- The significant finding is the CalderaAgent service being launched by services.exe through nssm.exe, which Microsoft Defender flagged as "Suspicious service launched."
- There is no direct evidence that malware or ransomware executed.
- There is evidence of persistence through a Windows service (T1569.002 – Service Execution).
- CalderaAgent detected due to an authorized red-team emulation exercise using MITRE CALDERA.
- Tuning the alert is not recommended as an attacker may use CALDERA or a similarly named service to maintain persistence.
- Alert closed off